

III The Hunnic Curse

There is no answer from above, so you ask with trembling voice.

—“Your mother...? IESOUS! MARIAM! IOSEF! Do you think...” In her last Wiccan act, she trapped you in this underground prison! Your companion in this ordeal has a more rueful explanation.

—“Well, she gets like that. In her drunken stupor, it is impossible to rouse her,” and his next yelling only confirms that, “Mother, in the name of the gods, will you wake up!! Mother!!!” You hear more banging and grunting, but it seems the weight of his mother on top of the door is too much for him and you hear him mumble

—“I guess it’s true what she always says, instead of strong muscles, I inherited the puny brain of my fathers. Why did I not secure the trapdoor, fool that I am!” Fathers? Plural? What is that supposed to mean? Perhaps it is your ignorance in Persian demonology, but even their bodily constitution...—okay, perhaps not the quandary to solve now. But you are still puzzled by his statement.

—“Fathers?” After some more banging and grunting, he replies

—“I hate to ask you, Your Grace, but perhaps you can lend me a hand—or rather a shoulder—to get us out of this unfortunate jam.”

—“Of course,” although, that is easier said than done in this complete darkness, for you bang your knees several times on the crooked stairs leading back up. Forcing you to crawl up on hands and feet—there goes this nice dress! And the air is so dry and dusty. You expected it to be damp, but the contrary is true. And so, to distract you from your current predicament, you ask once more, “Dear sire, what did you mean with fathers?”

—“*Alā*, a most unpleasant tale. Perhaps I should spare you this ignominy not suited for your delicate ears, Your Grace.”

—“Hah! These ears have tingled through quite some sordid tales, so regale me with your story, milord, as I am trying to find my way up here. Oww, *ballanbilaigonds*, *dungonitands*!!” That last bit was you slipping off a broken step and hitting your head against the wall.

—“Are you alright, Your Grace?” It’s funny that even in this precarious situation, he keeps up the pretense that you are an Aryan princess.

—“Yeah, yeah. Just those stupid stairs! Go on, tell me!”

—“As you wish. Well, it’s not much of a story really—and at the same time, a story all too common. *Alā*, my mother, she grew up in a little village in the Marwirod district—that’s all the way in the east—as the daughter

of the local *dahigān* [village head]. But then one day, a group of Huns invade her village and they find her, still a young girl, hiding in the stables. Three brutes. And they..., well, you can imagine what those barbarians would do to a pretty Persian girl. Anyway. They leave her for death. But somehow, she survives and finds out that she is pregnant. But of course, she never figures out whose seed.... Anyway, the *Shāhān-Shāh* takes pity on her—my grandparents lost their lives in the raid as did most of my kin—and so, an orphan now, she moves here, to Tisfon, where she raises me. She sees to it that I get a good education and now I am the master of this *dewān*,” he falls silent for a few moments, until he continues, “See, my mother, she was not always like this, Your Grace. It’s only recently, she has lost her way, where her drinking is no longer to the happiness of us, but to drown her own unhappiness. Wine can work both ways!” That’s actually sad, and you are now ashamed of your earlier disgust for the woman. Imagine what it would be like, as an orphan, to raise a little boy and do everything for him, in spite of the fact that he must be a constant reminder of the ill-fortune that has befallen you. Like that girl, that time those accursed *Benetous* [Blues] and *Prasinous* [Greens] raided your village—luckily, you had already moved to the orphanage. Somehow, miraculously, the poor Gothic girl survives the brutal rape and finds herself impregnated by one of her assailants. You always wondered how it must have been for her. You don’t exactly know what happened to her, for when her baby was a few years old, you heard that she all of a sudden had disappeared with her child. Never to be heard of again. You sometimes laid awake in your bed, picturing her story. Well, now you can at least find some solace that not all is lost. There was some comfort in his sad story. Although, it seems the vileness of the initial act is never going to wash away, its ugly head rearing up again in the drunken despair of his aging mother. You let out a sob, just thinking of it—it could have been your story. Probably a more likely Gothic tale than the one you were trying to conjure. There is always only one king, but always many, many orphans and widows and fallen men.... Luckily, before your mood cast you down the stairs again, you reach the top. At least, you assume you do, for your head bumps against his.... well, let’s just say, it’s too dark to tell. So, after some more embarrassing squirming—he must have apologized at least twenty times—so, after all not a sneaky demon—you finally get your shoulders against the door. But the pushing, it’s not going that great. Another thing he did not inherit from his mother: his scrawniness. She is quite heavy and even with

two pushing, the trapdoor barely gets lifted up. Some light peers through again, showing some smudges on his face. You can only presume that you won't look any better. But it's too heavy, and the door shuts again: back to unadulterated darkness.

—"Could you hear her breathe?!" IESOUS! MARIAM! IOSEF! Could she have passed? Another push, but not with much more success. If she really is dead, than you are never going to get out of here!

—"Is there no page or assistant who will come look for you?"

—"No, unfortunately, it is just me. I am the sole master of this *dewān*—being just cups and all, I guess, they didn't want to assign more men to it. It's just mother who comes visit me..." He lets out a loud sob. The poor man. And then, a loud snore. Thank the LORD, she is only asleep. He lets out another sob, and then apologizes.

—"No need to apologize, dear sire. Thankfully, your mother is okay." Only blocking the way out. And very heavy.

—"We need to pry this open with something, and then try to roll mother to the side. Wait here, Your Grace, there are some logs down there we can use. I know where they are."

—"I don't think I am going anywhere, dear sire. Just be careful. The steps are very dusty and slippery."

—"I'll be back soon." You hear him go down, and going by the sounds, involving some sliding as well. In the distance, you can hear the rumble of the thunderstorm, and another loud snore assures you that you are still locked in. There are other noises that you choose to ignore, like the scuttling of those four-legged critters you remember from the bowls of that ship. You have to compose yourself to not start panicking. Is this staircase getting narrower? Is the darkness getting tighter?

To not entirely loose your mind, you revisit the story of the master of the *dewān*. One thing he mentioned, that his father(s) were Huns. Now, you have learned about the Huns from your books that they are the former overlords of your people. Their leader was Attila, the most fearsome adversary Rome ever faced. It said that he was short of stature, with a broad chest and a large head; his eyes were small, his beard thin and sprinkled with gray; and he had a flat nose and swarthy skin, showing evidence of his origin.⁶ That are indeed some of the traits of your prison mate. Except the swarthy bit. But you remember also reading about the Huns that live

⁶Jordanes, 182.

near the Persian border—the ancestors of the master: they are the only ones among the Huns who have white bodies and countenances which are not ugly,⁷ and for that reason, they also call them White Huns. You don't know more about their history, as they never got involved in the West. But the Huns of Attila, they almost conquered the entire empire. And the Goths, and other peoples, like the Gepid, were their vassals. But when the great *Rex* Attila died [in 453], the Gepid *Rex* Hardureiks rebelled against his overlords, and that is how the Gepid became rulers of their own kingdom. Until the Lombard defeated them: but that is the story of your friend Alba. Yet, there is a part of her story that relates to the Huns, but one wouldn't find it in history books. It's Lombard lore, something that her handmaiden—the one who helped her escape the clutches of Empress Sofia—had told her—or perhaps she had come up with it? Alba called it the Hunnic curse. It all starts with *Rex* Attila, who falls in love with this young, beautiful maiden, Hildiko, and decides to marry her. At the wedding feast, the king drinks too much wine, so that, at their nuptial night, he is quite drunk. And he entices his new bride

~“Come, lovely wife, let us have one more drink from this cup.” But she says

~“It will be too much, Your Majesty.” But he insists.

~“Come, my bride, let us be jolly.”

~“Your Majesty, I will not fight you when you take my virginity, but, so help me the LORD, little as I may be, I will defend my sobriety.” See, this is a clever play on words, for her name, Hildiko, it means ‘little fighter.’ But the *Rex* does not heed her words and he first forces the cup and then himself upon her. But then Hildiko's curse comes true: later that night, he starts bleeding until, by morning, all blood has run out of him. Thus does drunkenness put a disgraceful end to a king renowned in war.⁸

But the curse does not end there! Much later, when Alba's father, *Rex* Albwin forces his wife Hrosamunda—Alba's second mama—to drink from the cup made out of the skull of her departed father, she too exclaims ~“Milord, I had no recourse when you took my virginity, but, so help me the LORD, by all the saints' horses, I will not let you take my sanity!” Also clever, for Hrosamunda's name, it means ‘she who is protected by horses.’ But Alba's father does not heed her words, and behold, the next morning,

⁷Prokopios, I.iii.4

⁸Jordanes, 254.

a dagger ends his life. And thus, *Rex* Albwin, who was most famous in war through the overthrow of so many enemies, perishes by the scheme of one little woman.⁹ Now, when Alba told you, you objected that her father was Lombard and not Hun, so why then call it a Hunnic curse? To which she replied that both he and Hrosamunda's father Kunimund, the former *Rex* of the Gepid, had served the Huns as their suzerain.

And that's not the end of the curse, for then once more, Hrosamunda is forced to drink a cup against her volition, by her new husband, Alba's uncle Helmilyis. See, someone had poisoned Helmilyis's cup—Alba thinks it must have been the Roman governor—and Helmilyis figured it out because it tasted so bitter. But, thinking that it was his wife Hrosamunda who had done this to him, when he felt that he had drunk the cup of death, he compelled her, drawing his sword upon her, to drink what was left.¹⁰ In anguish, Hrosamunda exclaims

~“My love, I have given you my flower, but now you will pluck this rose from the world!” Okay. This one took you a little longer to get: see, in Latin, her name is written *Rosamundi*, which literally means ‘rose of the world’. So, this then is the curse of the Hun: a Hun who forces a princess to drink a cup of wine at night, he will perish in the morn!

Meanwhile, the intrepid man has returned, holding some wooden stakes in his hands. With a lot of effort of the master of the demons and his Aryan princess—ha, ha—the trapdoor is pried open enough so that his mother can be pulled from it. And then, finally, light again. And air, for it was so dusty down there that your throat is parched. You have to sit down, catching your breath, as he exclaims.

—“*Pargast*, the cups. I forgot. Let me quickly go get them! Does Your Grace still want to see the *dewān*?” You had enough of *dew* or *dewān*, so you politely decline—his mother is still passed out and it doesn't look that you have much to fear from her in her present state. So, he disappears again, and you hear some clanging noises accompanied by some curses and then finally an ‘aha’. He emerges back, holding one of the golden cups up

—“Your Grace must be parched. Here, drink some of this sweet wine to quench your thirst. It will make you feel better right away, I promise you.” IESOUS! MARIAM! IOSEF! Is this then a replay of the Hunnic curse?! But

⁹Paul the Deacon, II.28.

¹⁰Paul the Deacon, II.29.

neither your name, nor your chastity are at play here. So, perhaps, you shouldn't refuse? You are way too thirsty...!